MODULE 3

CASE STUDY

Personio: Listening to Munich's HR Managers

How four TUM students discovered that 200,000 European companies run HR on Excel

Prepare this case before class. Come ready to take a position.

THE SITUATION

Personio, Late 2015

Hanno Renner and three co-founders have spent weeks interviewing HR managers at Munich SMEs. The pattern is unmistakable: companies with 10-200 employees manage recruiting, onboarding, time tracking, and payroll using Excel spreadsheets, paper forms, and email chains.

The pain is real and widespread. But the question is: where do they start? An all-in-one HR platform (ambitious but complex) or a single focused module?

KEY FACTS

- 4 TUM student founders
- 30+ customer interviews
- Target: 10-200 employee SMEs
- 200,000+ potential customers in DACH
- Competitors: SAP (enterprise), BambooHR (US)
- No European SME HR software leader

THE DECISION

Should Personio launch as an all-in-one HR platform or start with a single module?

OPTION A

All-in-one from day one — the pain is across the full HR workflow, not just one piece

OPTION B

Start with recruiting only — it's the most painful single module and has clear ROI

OPTION C

Start with time tracking — it's the simplest to build and every company needs it

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Come prepared to defend your position with evidence from the case.

1. What Jobs-to-be-Done did the HR managers describe? Map the functional, emotional, and social dimensions.
1. How would you apply the Mom Test to these interviews? What questions reveal real pain vs. polite agreement?
1. Use the F.I.T. framework to score the HR problem: Frequency, Intensity, Trend.
1. What's the risk of starting too broad vs. too narrow? How do you decide?